

both his Catholicism and his lowly birth. Inner stresses revealed themselves in a spate of psychosomatic illnesses. He above all despised the British ruling classes for failing to share his belief in the transcendental value of music. Made professor of music at Birmingham University—a post created for him in 1905—he used his lectures to deliver an attack on English cultural philistinism that astonished his patriotic admirers.

“ There is **music in the air ... the world is full of it** and you simply **take as much as you require.** ”

EDWARD ELGAR

Musical inspiration continued to flow. Elgar completed two of an intended trilogy of oratorios, *The Apostles* (1903) and *The Kingdom* (1906); he abandoned the third part. In 1908, his robust *First Symphony* repeated and even exceeded the triumph of *Pomp and Circumstance*, receiving almost a hundred performances in its first year. The symphony was also well received internationally, notably in the US and Germany.

The *Violin Concerto*, first performed by Austrian virtuoso Fritz Kreisler in 1910, was another enduring success. One of the most demanding works in the violin repertoire, it may have owed its emotional lyricism to Elgar's love for Alice Stuart Wortley, daughter of the British artist John Everett Millais and wife of an MP. If the romance did take place, there is no evidence that it